

EXPLORATION

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SINCE THE EARLIEST TIMES, people have been curious about the world in which they live. For more than 3,000 years, explorers have charted most of Earth's surface by land and sea. Often these brave pioneers went out into the unknown inspired by more than mere curiosity. Sometimes they went in search of riches, or to find new and less overcrowded places to live, or in a quest for scientific knowledge. In the course of mapping the world, explorers quashed many myths while bringing back true stories that could seem even stranger than fiction.

Exploration for trade

After the Ottomans captured Constantinople in 1453, European rulers paid sailors to find alternatives to the land route to Asia. It was soon proved quicker and cheaper to ship luxury goods such as spices and silks by sea.



Han dynasty (206 BC–220 AD) figurine

Chinese jade horse

Chinese dragon



Ivory imperial seal

Silk Road

In ancient and medieval times, there was a 6,400-km (4,000-mile) overland trade route between China and Europe, known as the Silk Road. It fell into disuse when Asian and European traders adopted new east-to-west sea routes in the 15th and 16th centuries.

Chinese silk

Bolts of silk were traded throughout the Silk Road.

Vasco da Gama

Portuguese navigator Vasco da Gama (c.1469–1524) became the first European to sail to India when he landed at Calicut (Calcutta) in 1498. Da Gama returned twice: in 1502 to avenge the deaths of some Christian traders, and for the last time, in 1524, as Viceroy of India. He died shortly after this appointment.



Aztec sacrificial knife



New World

From 1492 Europeans aimed to reach India by sailing west. When they discovered that America was in their path, they hailed this continent as a "new world". But as they explored it, they brutally plundered and destroyed the rich empires of the Aztec, Inca, and Maya.



Aztec portrait beaker

Ancient exploration

In ancient times, peoples such as the Phoenicians explored new regions in their quest for trading partners. The Greeks and Romans also discovered more about the world as their empires expanded. People began to read about far-flung places in books by classical geographers such as Strabo (c.63 BC–c.AD 21).

Xuan Zang

The Buddhist monk Xuan Zang (602–664) was one of the greatest travellers of ancient China. In 629 he set off alone on the famed Silk Road to visit India, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Pakistan, making friends for China and studying as he went. He returned in 654 laden with the finest Asian artworks. After Xuan Zang's death, the Emperor Gaozong built the Xingjiao monastery outside Xi'an to honour him.



Marco Polo

The Venetian pioneer trader Marco Polo (c.1254–1324) travelled overland to China, and served the Emperor Kublai Khan as a diplomat for 17 years. Back in Europe, while in prison for debt (1296–98), he dictated a hugely popular book about life in the Far East. Centuries later it helped inspire Columbus to find a new westward sea route to the East.

Kublai Khan and Marco Polo



Clove tree



Spice Islands

Europeans knew that valuable spices, such as cloves, grew wild in the East, and some of the greatest explorations were efforts to find the Spice Islands, which are today known as the Moluccas. Portuguese, Spanish, Dutch, and British navigators all fought to control this valuable source of trade for their countries.

Southern Continent

For centuries Europeans believed that there was a Terra Australis Incognita – or Unknown Southern Continent. In the 17th and 18th centuries Dutch and British seamen, such as James Cook (1728–79), began to explore it, and the great continent became known as Australia.

Robert O'Hara Burke and William J Wills

Early European settlement of Australia was coastal. Burke (1820–61) and Wills (1834–61) made the first journey from Melbourne across the continent's parched interior to the northern coast. On the way back, they died of starvation in the Outback.



Death at Cooper's Creek